The Death Constraint Model of the Desire Machine: Testable Hypothesis Set

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Date: 2026-08-13

Version: v1.0 (companion to EGS Theory Testable Hypothesis Set v1.1)

Abstract

This document presents two testable hypotheses from the Death Constraint Model (DCM) of the Desire Machine, a companion theory to the Existential Guarantee System (EGS) theory. Where EGS addresses how societies change when existential guarantees fail, DCM addresses how individuals respond when death pressure meets desire. Hypothesis A predicts that mortality salience increases normative compliance — the behavioral manifestation of desire encoding — moderated by perceived social enforcement. Hypothesis B proposes "desire quenching": individuals with long-held, high-investment desires show preemptive withdrawal as the desired object approaches realization, driven by the gap between maximal expectation and anticipated reality. Operational definitions, competing explanations, study designs, and falsification conditions are provided. The framework is offered freely to the research community under CC BY 4.0. EGS and DCM are theoretically related but empirically separable — each can fail independently without invalidating the other.

AI/LLM Use Disclosure

The author used AI/LLM tools to assist with drafting, structuring, and language editing of this manuscript. All theoretical content, constructs, hypotheses, and authorship decisions are the author's own; the author takes full responsibility for the content of this work.

> **Research program statement:** This document is an independent companion hypothesis set within the broader EGS/DCM research program. EGS addresses existential guarantee failure at the social-system level, while DCM addresses the individual-level dynamics of desire under mortality constraints. The two frameworks are theoretically related but **empirically separable** — each can fail independently without invalidating the other.
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> This document presents two testable hypotheses derived from the Death Constraint Model of the Desire Machine (DCM), a companion theory to the Existential Guarantee System (EGS) theory. Where EGS addresses how *societies* change when their existential guarantees fail, DCM addresses how *individuals* respond when death pressure meets desire.
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> **Intellectual lineage:** The model extends Deleuze & Guattari's desire production theory (not Freud's death drive) by adding death pressure as a *structural boundary condition* on desire: desire is not lack (Freud), not mere production (Deleuze), but production constrained by mortality. "Any system that persists must produce mechanisms for handling its own finitude."
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> **Honest status declaration:** Both hypotheses are theoretical derivations. Hypothesis B originates from the author's personal observation (n=1) subsequently generalized with psychological literature support. This is stated openly; the hypotheses are offered as falsifiable proposals requiring independent empirical test.

Theoretical Background (1-minute version)

Deleuze & Guattari's contribution: Desire is not lack; it is a productive force. Capitalism does not suppress desire — it decodes desire flows and re-encodes them into the capital circuit (deterritorialization → axiomatization → capture) (Deleuze & Guattari, 1972, 1980).

The added variable (DCM): Why do some desire-connections get produced and stabilized while others die? The answer proposed: because all existing beings face death pressure. Desire flows are *encoded* by social structures under death pressure into "normal behavior" — the formula:

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Desire production → social encoding → normal behavior
→ death pressure increases → encoding fails → escape lines → new structures
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Relationship to EGS: EGS theory (companion document) explains how societies' existential guarantee systems decay asymmetrically (positive promises die before negative sanctions — "fear outlives promise"). DCM explains the *individual-level psychological mechanisms* underlying that asymmetry: how death pressure shapes desire, and how desire defends itself when its objects fail.

Core Constructs

Construct	Definition	Notes
Death pressure	The subjective awareness of mortality and finitude, in any of six layers (individual/family/organization/institution/civilization/meaning)	Operationalized via standard mortality salience priming (TMT paradigm) in Hypothesis A; via domain-specific existential concerns scale in future work
Desire encoding	The process by which social structures channel desire flows into sanctioned forms ("normal behavior")	Manifest as normative compliance
Desire quenching	The defensive preemptive withdrawal of desire from an object, occurring when long-held expectations meet the threat of disappointing reality	Hypothesis B's core construct — "I'm not unable to have it; I no longer want it"

Hypothesis A: Death Pressure → Normative Compliance Encoding

> **H-A: Mortality salience increases normative compliance — the behavioral manifestation of desire encoding — and this effect is stronger when the encoding is perceived as socially enforced.**

Rationale: TMT demonstrates that mortality salience increases worldview defense (Greenberg, Pyszczynski & Solomon, 1986; Rosenblatt et al., 1989). DCM's incremental claim: worldview defense has a specific behavioral form — *compliance with socially enforced norms* — which is distinguishable from attitude-level worldview defense. When death pressure rises, individuals comply more with what society says is "normal," because normalcy is the encoded promise of existential safety.

The incremental claim vs. TMT: TMT's dependent variables are typically attitudes (outgroup derogation, punishment of moral violators). DCM predicts a *behavioral* outcome — conformity to normative scripts in everyday choices — that is theoretically downstream of attitude defense and testable separately.

Operational definitions:

Variable	Definition	Measurement
Mortality salience	Standard TMT priming	Writing about one's own death vs. dental pain (Rosenblatt et al., 1989 paradigm)
Normative compliance (DV)	Willingness to follow socially sanctioned behavioral scripts	Behavioral choice tasks: e.g., choosing "socially expected" options over "individual preference" options in vignettes (career path, consumption, lifestyle); compliance with normative messages
Perceived social enforcement (moderator)	Belief that deviating from the norm carries social/economic cost	3-5 item scale ("If I deviate from the expected path, people will think less of me / I will lose opportunities")

Testable predictions: - **P-A1:** Mortality salience (vs. control) increases normative compliance behavior (expected d ≈ 0.2–0.4, consistent with typical TMT effect sizes) - **P-A2:** The MS → compliance effect is moderated by perceived social enforcement: stronger among individuals who believe norms are socially enforced - **P-A3:** P-A1–P-A2 hold when controlling for social desirability bias and dispositional conformity (e.g., need for closure)

Competing explanations to rule out: - TMT attitude defense alone (no behavioral increment) — ruled out by including both attitude and behavioral DVs - Social desirability / demand characteristics — ruled out via control measures and behavioral (not self-report) DVs - Generalized anxiety priming (not death-specific) — ruled out via aversive control condition (dental pain standard)

Falsification conditions: - H-A is wrong if: (1) MS does not increase normative compliance in a preregistered replication; (2) the effect is fully accounted for by attitude defense (no incremental behavioral variance); (3) the moderation by perceived enforcement fails.

Study design suggestion: 2 (MS vs. control) × measured perceived enforcement, N ≥ 200/cell. Preregistered. Single country first (China — high social enforcement context) then cross-cultural comparison (US).

Hypothesis B: Desire Quenching — Preemptive Withdrawal of Desire

> **H-B: Individuals with long-held, high-investment desires show *preemptive withdrawal* (quenching) as the desired object approaches realization — driven by the gap between expectation (reference point at maximum) and anticipated reality (any actual version loses to imagination).**

The phenomenon: "I've wanted this for years. Now that it's almost mine, I find I no longer want it." The person withdraws desire *before* disappointment can arrive, preserving the narrative: "I didn't lose; I chose not to want."

Origin note (honest): This hypothesis originates from the author's personal experience (n=1) — a long-anticipated relationship goal that extinguished upon approach to realization. The author then found convergent support in existing literature (reference point effects, defensive pessimism, Zeigarnik effect) and generalized it. It is offered as a falsifiable proposal, explicitly acknowledging its origin.

Proposed mechanism (five components): 1. **Imagination > reality:** Prolonged anticipation builds imagined versions of the object that exceed any actual version (cognitive simulation research) 2. **Reference point at maximum:** Anticipation pushes the reference point (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979) to the imagined optimum; any real outcome is experienced as a relative *loss* against the reference point 3. **Anticipatory consumption:** Fantasy partially pre-consumes the desired experience, reducing marginal utility of the real event 4. **Meaning vacuum upon completion:** After years of "the goal" being the only horizon, its achievement leaves no next goal (Zeigarnik-tension extension) — completion = loss of structure 5. **Defensive withdrawal (DCM's addition):** The person preemptively withdraws before step 2-4 can occur — protecting the self-narrative "I could have had it" over the reality "I had it and it disappointed"

Operational definitions:

Variable	Definition	Measurement
Anticipation intensity	Duration + emotional investment in a desired object/goal	Retrospective/current measures: "How long have you wanted this?" "How much of your mental life has it occupied?"

Variable	Definition	Measurement
Reference point gap	Discrepancy between imagined ideal and expected actual	"Rate your imagined ideal version (0-100)" vs. "Rate how good the real version is likely to be (0-100)" — gap = difference
Withdrawal tendency (DV)	Willingness to continue pursuing vs. preemptively abandon at the approach of realization	Behavioral vignettes: "The goal is now achievable. Would you: (a) pursue it, (b) delay, (c) find reasons it's not worth it, (d) abandon"
Post-outcome satisfaction (for validation)	If pursued and achieved, satisfaction vs. expectation	0-100 rating post-outcome

Testable predictions: - **P-B1:** Anticipation intensity positively predicts withdrawal tendency at the approach of realization (controlling for trait neuroticism and general approach-avoidance) - **P-B2:** The reference point gap mediates the anticipation → withdrawal relationship - **P-B3:** Withdrawal is stronger for *identity-defining* desires (goals tied to self-worth) than for instrumental desires - **P-B4:** Among those who do pursue and achieve, satisfaction is negatively predicted by pre-achievement anticipation intensity (imagination > reality)

Competing explanations to rule out: - Defensive pessimism (Norem & Cantor, 1986): lowered expectations to protect against failure — overlapping but distinct: quenching is withdrawal *of desire itself*, not mere expectation adjustment; distinguish by measuring desire intensity change, not just expectation - Self-handicapping (Berglas & Jones, 1978): creates excuses *after* pursuing; quenching withdraws *before* pursuing — distinguish by timing - Anticipated regret (Bell, 1982): deciding against to avoid future regret — control via regret measures - Burnout/fatigue: prolonged wanting exhausts — control via goal fatigue measures

Falsification conditions: - H-B is wrong if: (1) P-B1 fails in a preregistered study; (2) the withdrawal is fully explained by defensive pessimism or self-handicapping (no incremental desire-intensity change); (3) reference point gap does not mediate.

Study design suggestion: Study B1 (correlational): retrospective survey of goal pursuit episodes (N ≥ 300), measuring anticipation, gap, withdrawal, outcome satisfaction. Study B2 (prospective): track a real approaching goal (e.g., exam candidates, couples nearing marriage, career transitions) over 3-6 months; measure desire intensity trajectory and withdrawal. B2 is the decisive test.

Relationship Between A and B (the unified picture)

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Death pressure (high)
    ↓
H-A: Desire encoded into normative compliance ("be normal, be safe")
    ↓
EGS fulfillment declines ("normal" no longer delivers)
    ↓
H-B: Desire quenches before disappointment ("I no longer want what the system promised")
    ↓
Escape lines (future work: rebellion vs. anesthesia; AI companions as new encoding)
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A and B are two mechanisms at two points in one chain: A is desire *under* death pressure (encoding), B is desire *defending itself* when encoding fails (quenching). Together with EGS (the system level), they form the complete model.

General Falsifiability and Limitations

The model is wrong if: 1. H-A fails (mortality salience does not increase normative compliance beyond attitude defense) 2. H-B fails (desire does not quench preemptively; withdrawal fully explained by existing constructs) 3. Both H-A and H-B replicate but the EGS link fails (compliance/quenching uncorrelated with perceived fulfillment) — the unified chain is unsupported

Known limitations (author's explicit acknowledgment): - H-B originates from n=1 observation, subsequently grounded in literature; requires independent replication before strong claims - Both hypotheses need scale development and psychometric validation - Cross-cultural generalization (China vs. US/West) is hypothesized but untested; collectivist vs. individualist contexts may shift effect magnitudes - The model does not yet specify individual-difference moderators (age, gender, attachment style) — future work

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Usage License and Authorship

Authorship: If subsequent research substantially builds on the theoretical framework introduced here, researchers are encouraged to cite this work appropriately and to discuss contribution and authorship at the outset of collaboration, in accordance with the relevant journal's and institution's authorship policies.

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Appendix: References

Source	Type	Verifiability
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